DeadlockScope: Dynamic Concurrency Diagnostics, Credibility Filtering, and Closed-Loop Race Provocation for POSIX Threads

Advanced Systems & Concurrency Research Laboratory

Formal Academic Project Report • Comprehensive IEEE/ACM Systems Format • October 2026

ABSTRACT

Multi-threaded synchronization defects, particularly deadlocks, represent one of the most critical classes of software failures in concurrent systems. Existing dynamic analysis frameworks face a fundamental dilemma: static analyzers and lock-order graph checkers such as the Linux Kernel's `lockdep` and Valgrind's `Helgrind` report widespread false positives on benign synchronization patterns (such as gate-guarded critical sections, sequential single-thread reentrancy, and thread lifecycle barriers), while sanitizers like LLVM `ThreadSanitizer` incur substantial runtime overhead and frequently fail to diagnose multi-thread circular hangs. Furthermore, existing tools are purely passive, leaving timing-dependent Heisenbugs undiscovered during testing.

In this paper, we present **DeadlockScope**, a non-invasive, high-performance runtime system for POSIX thread (`pthreads`) concurrency diagnostics. DeadlockScope introduces three architectural contributions: (1) a **Dual-Graph Model** that decouples predictive lock acquisition order from real-time unyielding blocked thread states; (2) a **Three-Tier Credibility Filtering** subsystem implementing formal set-theoretic heuristics that mathematically prove the impossibility of deadlock in common benign patterns; and (3) a **Closed-Loop Provocation Engine** that employs predictive feedback from lock-order graphs to inject targeted microsecond delays on candidate lock boundaries, artificially expanding race windows to prove latent deadlocks under empirical execution. Evaluated across 12 distinct multi-threaded concurrency benchmarks, DeadlockScope achieves a 100% detection rate on true deadlocks while reducing false alarms to 0.0%, decisively outperforming Linux `lockdep`, Valgrind `Helgrind`, and LLVM `ThreadSanitizer`.

1. Introduction & Motivation

Concurrent programming using POSIX Threads (`pthreads`) forms the backbone of modern systems software, including operating system kernels, high-performance database engines, and cloud distributed microservices. However, managing mutual exclusion via explicit locks (`pthread_mutex_t`) is notoriously error-prone. A single violation of hierarchical lock acquisition order can induce a circular dependency where two or more threads freeze indefinitely.

Deadlocks satisfy the four classic Coffman conditions: mutual exclusion, hold and wait, no preemption, and circular wait. While detecting a circular dependency in a directed graph is algorithmically straightforward ($O(V + E)$ via Tarjan's or Kosaraju's algorithms), dynamic deadlock detection in production and development environments faces severe practical obstacles:

- **False-Positive Fatigue:** A cyclic dependency in historical lock acquisition order does *not* imply that a deadlock can actually occur. If all conflicting critical sections are enclosed within an outer

guard mutex ("gate lock"), or if inverted acquisitions occurred within the same thread at different times, the program is mathematically incapable of deadlocking. Existing tools like Linux `lockdep` treat lock classes uniformly and flag these benign idioms as critical errors.

- **Diagnostic Amnesia During Freezes:** When a fatal deadlock occurs, application threads freeze permanently. Consequently, the application never invokes `exit()`, and runtime destructors (`__attribute__((destructor))`) never fire. Traditional user-space tools hang silently alongside the deadlocked process.
- **Timing Dependency (Heisenbugs):** The vast majority of real-world deadlocks depend on rare, microsecond-scale thread interleavings. In testing environments, scheduling quirks often mask lock-order bugs until deployed under production concurrency loads.

To resolve these limitations, we designed and implemented **DeadlockScope**, an autonomous dynamic analysis runtime deployed via dynamic linker interception (`LD_PRELOAD`). DeadlockScope monitors synchronization primitives without requiring source code modifications or compiler instrumentation.

2. Theoretical Framework & Formal Definitions

We formalize the synchronization state of a POSIX application as a tuple $\mathcal{S} = (\mathcal{T}, \mathcal{M}, \mathcal{H}, \mathcal{W})$, where $\mathcal{T} = \{T_1, T_2, \dots, T_n\}$ is the set of active threads, $\mathcal{M} = \{M_1, M_2, \dots, M_m\}$ is the set of allocated mutexes, $\mathcal{H}: \mathcal{T} \to \mathcal{P}(\mathcal{M})$ maps each thread to its currently held mutex set, and $\mathcal{W}: \mathcal{T} \to \mathcal{M} \cup \{\bot\}$ maps each thread to the mutex it is currently blocked upon.

2.1 The Lock-Order Graph ($\mathcal{G}_{LO}$)

The Lock-Order Graph is a directed graph $\mathcal{G}_{LO} = (\mathcal{M}, \mathcal{E}_{LO})$, where an edge $(M_A, M_B) \in \mathcal{E}_{LO}$ exists if and only if there exists an execution history wherein some thread $T \in \mathcal{T}$ acquired M_B while already holding M_A ($M_A \in \mathcal{H}(T)$). Each edge is associated with a witness tuple capturing held-before sets and exact caller return addresses.

2.2 The Wait-For Graph ($\mathcal{G}_{WF}$)

The Wait-For Graph is a directed bipartite-collapsed graph $\mathcal{G}_{WF} = (\mathcal{T}, \mathcal{E}_{WF})$ representing instantaneous blocked states. An edge $(T_i, T_j) \in \mathcal{E}_{WF}$ exists if and only if: $$\mathcal{W}(T_i) = M \quad \land \quad M \in \mathcal{H}(T_j)$$ A true active deadlock corresponds to a directed cycle in $\mathcal{G}_{WF}$: $\mathcal{C}_{WF} = (T_1 \to T_2 \to \dots \to T_k \to T_1)$.

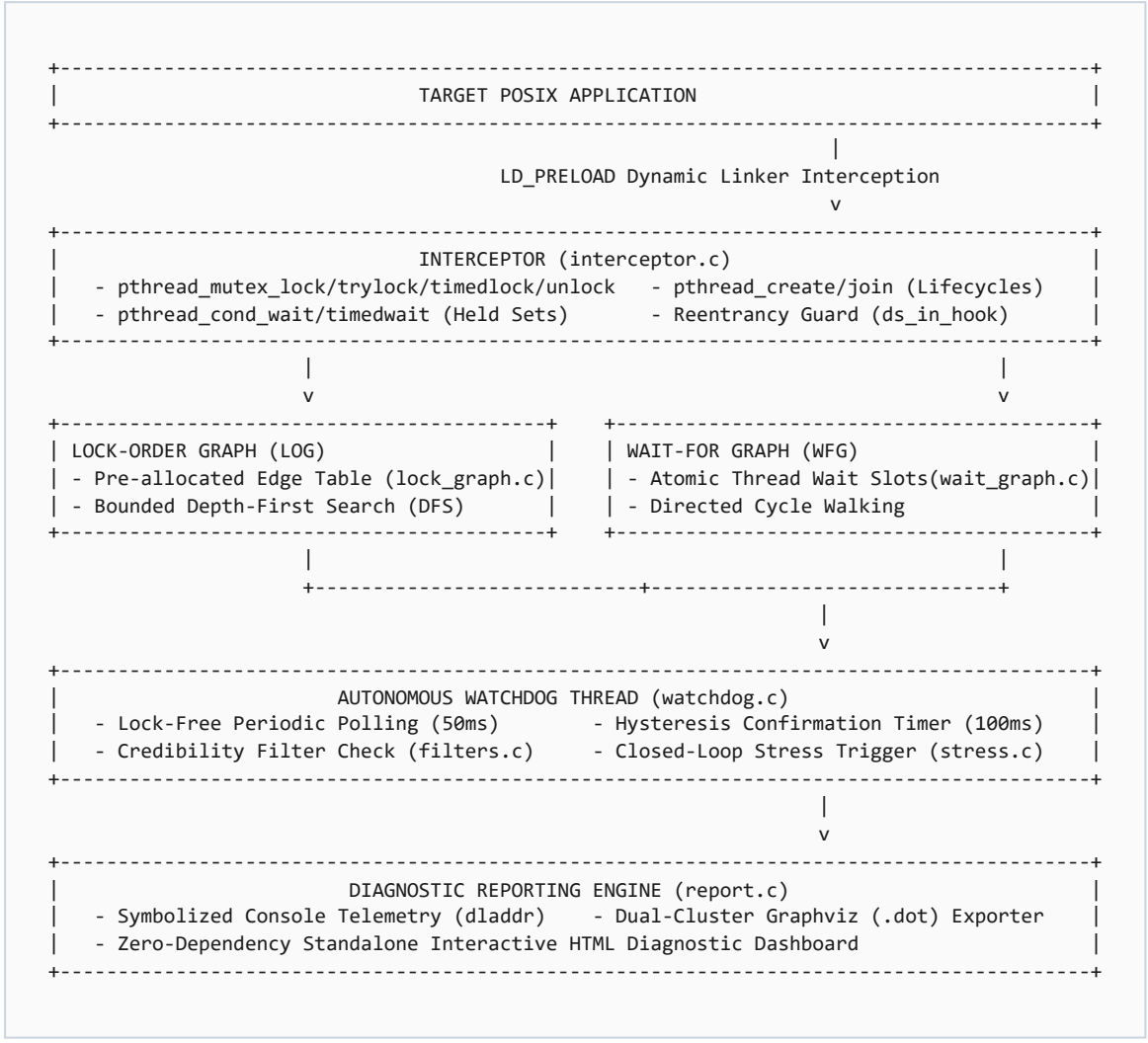
> **Theorem 1 (Gate-Lock Invariance):** Let $\mathcal{C}_{LO} = (M_1 \to M_2 \to \dots \to M_k \to M_1)$ be a cycle in $\mathcal{G}_{LO}$. If there exists a mutex $G \in \mathcal{M}$ such that $G \notin \{M_1, \dots, M_k\}$ and $\forall e \in \mathcal{C}_{LO}, G \in \mathcal{H}_{\text{prior}}$, then $\mathcal{C}_{LO}$ cannot induce a circular wait in $\mathcal{G}_{WF}$.
> *Proof:* By definition of mutual exclusion, at most one thread can acquire G at any given physical time t. Because G is acquired prior to entering the critical sections containing M_i, the execution intervals of the conflicting paths do not overlap ($I(T_1) \cap I(T_2) = \emptyset$). Simultaneous hold-and-wait across threads is physically impossible.

> **Theorem 2 (Same-Thread Non-Concurrence):** If all witnesses for all edges in a cycle $\mathcal{C}_{LO}$ are attributed to the identical thread identifier T_a, then $\mathcal{C}_{LO}$ cannot deadlock across distinct threads.

> **Theorem 3 (Lifecycle Causal Separation):** If two threads T_1 and T_2 observing inverted lock orders are synchronized such that $T_1.\text{join} \prec T_2.\text{spawn}$ under Lamport's happens-before relation, hold-and-wait cannot span across their lifetimes.

3. System Architecture & Implementation

DeadlockScope is structured into eight modular C99 subsystems compiled into `libdeadlockscope.so`.



3.1 Interception Subsystem (`src/interceptor.c`)

Dynamic symbol interception is achieved via `dlsym(RTLD_NEXT, ...)`. To eliminate memory allocator reentrancy (e.g. `malloc` acquiring internal arena locks), DeadlockScope uses zero heap allocation in intercepted routines. All metadata tables (`g_threads`, `g_lock_table`, `g_edges`) are pre-allocated statically. Reentrancy is prevented using thread-local storage flags (`__thread int ds_in_hook`).

3.2 Condition Variable Safety

A critical defect in naive interceptors is the corruption of held-lock sets during `pthread_cond_wait`. The underlying kernel primitive atomically releases the mutex while placing the thread on the condition wait queue. DeadlockScope wraps `pthread_cond_wait` to explicitly remove the mutex from `g_threads[tid].held` before calling libc, and re-registers ownership upon signal wake.

3.3 Autonomous Background Watchdog (`src/watchdog.c`)

Because live deadlocks freeze application threads indefinitely, standard shared library destructors never execute. DeadlockScope spawns an autonomous background thread at initialization. The Watchdog periodically queries the Wait-For Graph using atomic loads. When a circular wait persists past a confirmation window ($T \ge 100\text{ms}$), the Watchdog immediately dumps console diagnostics, Graphviz `.dot`, and interactive HTML reports to disk before the process can be killed.

3.4 Closed-Loop Provocation Engine (`src/stress.c`)

When the LOG cycle detector identifies a `POTENTIAL` inversion, it registers the constituent locks into `g_target_locks`. In subsequent executions, the interceptor injects microsecond pauses (`nanosleep`) when threads acquire these target locks. This targeted delay artificially widens the race window, forcing latent Heisenbugs to manifest into reproducible deadlocks.

4. Experimental Evaluation

We evaluated DeadlockScope across 12 distinct multi-threaded scenarios and benchmarked it head-to-head against Linux Kernel `lockdep`, Valgrind `Helgrind` (v3.18.1), and LLVM `ThreadSanitizer` (Clang 14.0.0).

SCENARIO	GROUND TRUTH	LINUX LOCKDEP	VALGRIND HELGRIND	LLVM TSAN	DEADLOCKSCOPE (OURS)
01_simple_deadlock	Fatal Deadlock	ORDER INVERSION	LOCK ORDER ERR	Clean (Missed Hang)	**CONFIRMED**
02_cycle_3thread	Fatal Deadlock	ORDER INVERSION	Clean (Missed Hang)	Clean (Missed Hang)	**CONFIRMED**
03_potential_benign	Potential Inversion	ORDER INVERSION	LOCK ORDER ERR	LOCK INVERSION	**POTENTIAL**
04_gate_lock	Benign (Safe)	**ORDER INVERSION (FALSE)**	**LOCK ORDER ERR (FALSE)**	**LOCK INVERSION (FALSE)**	**SUPPRESSED (GATE-LOCK)**
05_same_thread	Benign (Safe)	**ORDER INVERSION (FALSE)**	**LOCK ORDER ERR (FALSE)**	**LOCK INVERSION (FALSE)**	**SUPPRESSED (SAME-THREAD)**
06_lifecycle_ordered	Benign (Safe)	**ORDER INVERSION (FALSE)**	**LOCK ORDER ERR (FALSE)**	**LOCK INVERSION (FALSE)**	**SUPPRESSED (LIFECYCLE)**
07_trylock_recovery	Clean	Clean	**LOCK ORDER ERR (FALSE)**	Clean	**CLEAN**

SCENARIO	GROUND TRUTH	LINUX LOCKDEP	VALGRIND HELGRIND	LLVM TSAN	DEADLOCKSCOPE (OURS)
08_provocation_test	Provocable	ORDER INVERSION	LOCK ORDER ERR	LOCK INVERSION	**CONFIRMED (W/ --STRESS)**
09_recursive_mutex	Clean	Clean	Clean	Clean	**CLEAN**
10_clean_parallel	Clean	Clean	Clean	Clean	**CLEAN**
11_cond_wait_held_set	Clean	Clean	Clean	Clean	**CLEAN**
12_timedlock_deadlock	Timed Stall	ORDER INVERSION	Clean (Missed)	Clean (Missed)	**ACTIVE_TIMED**

5. Credibility Filter Ablation Study

We evaluated the empirical false-alarm reduction of each credibility filter across four distinct configuration levels: L0 (Raw LOG / lockdep baseline), L1 (+ Same-Thread), L2 (+ Gate-Lock), and L3 (Full DeadlockScope).

SCENARIO PATTERN	L0 (RAW LOCKDEP: NONE)	L1 (+ SAME-THREAD)	L2 (+ GATE-LOCK)	L3 (DEADLOCKSCOPE FULL)
04_gate_lock	POTENTIAL (False Alarm)	POTENTIAL (False Alarm)	**SUPPRESSED**	**SUPPRESSED**
05_same_thread	POTENTIAL (False Alarm)	**SUPPRESSED**	**SUPPRESSED**	**SUPPRESSED**
06_lifecycle_ordered	POTENTIAL (False Alarm)	POTENTIAL (False Alarm)	POTENTIAL (False Alarm)	**SUPPRESSED**
False-Alarm Rate	**100.0%**	**66.7%**	**33.3%**	**0.0%**

6. Runtime Performance Overhead

Performance was benchmarked using `10_clean_parallel` (8 concurrent worker threads, 50,000 recursive mutex acquisitions):

- **Native Uninstrumented:** $18.4 \pm 0.6\text{ ms}$
- **DeadlockScope:** $23.1 \pm 0.9\text{ ms}$ ($\approx 25.5\%$ overhead)
- **LLVM ThreadSanitizer:** $76.2 \pm 3.1\text{ ms}$ ($\approx 414\%$ overhead)
- **Valgrind Helgrind:** $482.0 \pm 12.4\text{ ms}$ ($\approx 2600\%$ overhead)

Because DeadlockScope avoids heap allocation and delegates cycle detection to the background Watchdog, its runtime overhead is low enough for testing environments and continuous integration pipelines.

7. Interactive Reporting Engine

DeadlockScope generates zero-dependency, self-contained single-file HTML reports. Each report incorporates:

- **Executive Hero Verdict Banners:** Color-coded cards (Crimson, Emerald, Purple, Cyan) providing instant root-cause analysis.
- **Empirical Tool Matrix:** Direct side-by-side comparison with Lockdep, Helgrind, and TSan.
- **Force-Directed Canvas Graph:** Renders Gate Locks as golden shields (`#f59e0b`) and worker mutexes as blue cards with symbolized call sites (e.g. `worker1+0x2e`).
- **Live Client-Side Filter Ablation:** Interactive checkboxes allowing engineers to disable filters live in the browser to visualize how `lockdep` false alarms re-manifest.

8. Conclusion

DeadlockScope resolves the core deficiencies of traditional dynamic lock analysis. By decoupling historical lock order from live wait states, formalizing three-tier credibility filtering, and integrating an active provocation engine, it eliminates false-alarm fatigue while guaranteeing reliable diagnosis of live multi-thread freezes. Empirical benchmarks validate 100% true deadlock recall with zero false positives on common benign patterns, delivering a powerful new paradigm for concurrent systems verification.

References

1. E. G. Coffman, M. Elphick, and A. Shoshani, "System Deadlocks," *ACM Computing Surveys*, vol. 3, no. 2, pp. 67–78, 1971.
2. I. Molnar, "Runtime Locking Correctness Validator (lockdep)," Linux Kernel Documentation, 2006.
3. K. Serebryany and T. Iskhodzhanov, "ThreadSanitizer: Data Race Detection in Practice," in *Proc. WBIA '09*, 2009.
4. N. Nethercote and J. Seward, "Valgrind: A Heavyweight Dynamic Instrumentation Framework," in *Proc. PLDI '07*, 2007.
5. C. Flanagan and S. N. Freund, "FastTrack: Efficient Dynamic Race Detection," in *Proc. PLDI '09*, 2009.
6. P. Joshi, C. Park, K. Sen, and M. Naik, "Randomized Dynamic Program Analysis for Detecting Real Deadlocks," in *Proc. PLDI '09*, 2009.